

Project Ledger

Part 2: Consolidation, A Step-by-Step Guide for Virtual Assistants (No Coding Required)

What this guide teaches: how to set up and run a tool that reads a batch of text-based transaction report files, pulls out the transaction data, and consolidates everything into one clean, formatted Excel master sheet, complete with a summary tab.

Who this is for: a virtual assistant with no programming background, working on a Windows computer, who has been given a batch of report files by a client or supervisor. Pairs well with Part 1: Extraction if your files start out inside password-protected archives, but works on its own with any similarly-formatted .txt files.

This tool masks sensitive account and card numbers by default, everywhere: on screen, in searches, and in the exported file. See the Security section below before you begin.

Before You Start: What You Decide vs. What Your Client Decides

This tool has a few settings that must come from your client or supervisor, never guess these. Everything else is yours to operate independently once it's set up.

Needs client/supervisor input	You can decide/operate independently
Which file naming pattern counts as a "target file" (the Target File Settings fields)	Which folder to use as output location
Whether sensitive-field masking should ever be turned off (default is always ON, and should stay on unless told otherwise)	Re-running the tool when new report files arrive
Where the final Excel master sheet should ultimately be delivered or filed	Using search and sort to review data before export
Any change to what counts as a complete, correct consolidation for their business process	Basic troubleshooting using the steps in this guide

Rule of thumb: masking is a client decision, always. If a client wants full numbers, get that in writing first. Everything else that's easy to see and fix on your own is yours to handle.

Security Spotlight: Why This Tool Masks Data by Default

This tool works with real account numbers and card numbers, genuinely sensitive financial data. A common mistake in tools like this is treating that data the same as any other column: fully visible, easy to accidentally screenshot, share, or leave open on a shared screen.

This tool takes a different approach. The "Mask account and card numbers" setting is ON by default, and it applies everywhere at once: the on-screen table, the search results, and the exported Excel file. A masked account number like 10000128 displays as XXXX0128, the last 4 digits only, enough to verify a record without exposing the full number.

Turning masking off requires an active decision, with a warning dialog explaining the risk. A VA using this tool has to deliberately choose to see full numbers, they can never end up showing them by accident.

As a VA, treat this the same way you'd treat any other client credential: leave masking on unless your client has explicitly told you, in writing, that they need full numbers for a specific reason.

Section 1: What You'll Need

- A Windows computer with an internet connection
- The batch of report files you need to consolidate (in any folder, they don't need to be organized in any particular way)
- The three files provided with this guide: `install_setup_part2.bat`, `run_consolidator.bat`, and `financial_report_consolidator_part2.py`

Section 2: One-Time Computer Setup

This only needs to be done once per computer, and is completely separate from Part 1's setup, if you also have that tool, this won't affect it.

Step 1: Create a folder

On the Desktop, right-click an empty space, choose New, then Folder. Name it **BatchFinancialReportProcessing_Part2**. Open it, everything else goes inside.

Step 2: Save the three provided files into that folder

If you received the files as actual files, simply copy them into the folder. If you received their contents as pasted text, use Notepad to recreate them: open Notepad, paste in the full contents, click File then Save As, change "Save as type" to All Files, type the exact file name including its ending, and save it in the folder.

A correctly saved .bat file shows a small gear icon in Windows. If you see a notepad icon instead, it saved as a text file by mistake, repeat the Save As step.

Step 3: Run the setup script

- Double-click install_setup_part2.bat
- A black window opens, this is normal. Press any key to begin.
- It automatically installs Python and the openpyxl add-on if either is missing. This can take a few minutes. Do not close the window.
- When it says "Setup complete!", press any key to close it.

Step 4: Close and reopen the folder

This matters the first time only. Close the folder window completely, then open it again, so your computer recognizes anything newly installed.

Section 3: Running the Tool

Step 1: Launch it

Double-click run_consolidator.bat. A window should open with a left panel of controls and a right panel showing a data table.

Step 2: Fill in the left panel

- **Source Folder:** the folder containing the report files. The tool searches this folder and everything inside it.
- **Output Folder:** where the Excel master sheet should be saved.
- **Target File Settings:** what the files start with, and what file type they are. Get this from your client, don't guess.
- **Security Settings:** leave "Mask account and card numbers" checked unless told otherwise by your client.

Step 3: Load and review

Click "Load Report Files." The table fills in as files are processed, and you can search, sort by clicking column headers, or double-click any row for full details before exporting.

Step 4: Generate the Excel master sheet

Click "Generate Master Excel Sheet." The output file has two tabs: Master Transactions (every record, formatted with a filterable header row) and Summary (transaction counts and totals grouped by year and month).

Section 4: Troubleshooting

What you see	What to do
Blue "Windows protected your PC" screen	Click "More info" then "Run anyway." Expected for files not from the Windows Store, doesn't mean the file is unsafe.
"openpyxl is not installed" message	Run install_setup_part2.bat again, then restart the tool.
"No matching files found"	Double-check the Target File Settings match your client's actual file naming.
Numbers look masked and you need full ones	Confirm with your client first, then uncheck the masking box and confirm the warning dialog.

Appendix: Files Included With This Guide

File	Purpose
install_setup_part2.bat	Run once per computer. Installs Python and openpyxl if missing.
run_consolidator.bat	Double-click to launch the tool. Use this every time.
financial_report_consolidator_part2.py	The tool itself. Do not rename or edit unless instructed.